PRINCIPAL NAIDU



Some Andhra Pradesh IAS officers are beginning to feel like schoolkids before the headmaster. Every three months, they have to endure a two-day collectors' conference where CM **N. Chandrababu Naidu** reviews the state's progress and, just as closely, their own. In a hall packed with ministers, the chief secretary and even junior officials, slow-moving files can invite a public dressing down. Last week came a fresh rule—no mobile phones. Naidu had noticed that some officers were scrolling a tad too much rather than paying full attention at the marathon meetings.

NITISH JANATA DAL?



JD(U) working president Sanjay Jha wants **Nitish Kumar's** name formally embedded in the party's identity. On September 13, Bihar unit president Umesh Kushwaha also backed the idea, saying the Janata Dal of today is synonymous with the former Bihar CM. The JD(U), which once drew strength from the idea of a united political formation, now appears to believe that Nitish's name is the stronger adhesive. It's an intriguing turn of events for the ex-CM too, after spending years cautioning against personality-driven politics.

GARBA STAYS SECULAR



Navratri politics has arrived early in Maharashtra. The Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP) doesn't want Muslims at garba-dandiya venues, asking organisers to check Aadhaar cards to establish the ID of participants. Cabinet minister Nitesh Rane of the BJP backed the campaign, connecting garba venues to "love jihad" hunting grounds. But then came an awkward intervention from **Amruta Fadanavis**, wife of CM Devendra Fadnavis, who declared that the garba was an inclusive celebration and everyone should be welcome. The BJP, too, said it had sought no ban. And Rane now feels Muslims with "clean intentions" can join. The VHP, though, refuses to budge.

Kaushik Deka *with* Jumana Shah, Ashish Misra, Prasad Nichenametla, Amitabh Srivastava *and* Dhaval S. Kulkarni

ECO WATCH

ORANGUTANS IN ODISHA

TRAFFICKED APES RAISE ALARM

By **Jumana Shah**

Five baby orangutans, believed to have been smuggled in from Southeast Asia, are in quarantine at Bhubaneswar's Nandankanan Zoological Park. Recovered from Odisha's Balasore district, the incident has triggered a probe into an international wildlife trafficking network. Forest officials recovered the baby apes, aged between six months and one year, from the Bichitrapur forest area in the Jaleswar range in the first week of September.

Odisha environment minister Ram Singh Khuntia says investigators suspect an international racket. Indonesia's ministry of forestry is now coordinating with Indian authorities and CITES (Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora), the treaty body governing trade in endangered species, to repatriate the animals. They remain in a temperature-controlled quarantine facility at the zoo pending that process. Investigators are also examining possible links to two earlier cases involving orangutans in India, one in Manipur, where a wildlife trafficker was arrested, and another in Maharashtra's Thane district in November 2024, where a smuggled orangutan and seized reptiles were found in appalling conditions inside a residential flat. No arrests have been made in that case.

Orangutans are only found in the wild in Sumatra and Borneo, and are in the critically endangered list of the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature). Cross-border seizures of young orangutans are a recurring feature of Southeast Asia's illegal wildlife trade. The Borneo Orangutan Survival Foundation estimates that four out of five orangutans captured and moved through illegal trade—estimated to number over 4,000 a year—die in transit or within the first year of their captivity.



PTI